



ATC Training and Standards Policy

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VERSION 1.0

WARNING!

Information contained in this document is intended
for flight simulation purposes only.

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Purpose of Document

This document establishes the official ATC Training Policy for VATSIM Sub-Saharan Africa (VATSSA). It sets out the standards, expectations, and procedures governing all ATC training activities conducted within the VATSSA division.

This policy has been developed to achieve the following objectives:

- Ensure high-quality ATC training throughout the VATSSA division.
- Provide students with a clear understanding of their responsibilities, rights, and progression pathways.
- Support mentors and examiners in maintaining consistent and fair training standards.
- Provide a comprehensive and structured framework for all members of the VATSSA Training Department.
- Ensure that the VATSSA training process is carried out with transparency, fairness, and without bias or favouritism.

VATSSA is committed to delivering a professional and supportive training environment for all students, regardless of their home region. This policy applies to all ATC training students within the VATSSA division, including those awaiting mentor assignment.

1. Control Pages

1.1. Document Identification

Type	Policy
Revision	01/2026
Issue Date	
Effective Date	
Prepared By	Luke Van Zyl & Clark King
Approved By	Wian Saptouw – VATSSA1 (Division Director)
Next Review Due	1st January 2027
Identification	VATSSA_POL_ATC_Training_05-2026.pdf

1.2. Revision Records

Version	Date	Description	Author
1.3	04/2026	Initial Policy Drafted	Luke Van Zyl & Clark King

2. General Provisions

2.1. Applicability

This policy applies to all ATC training students in the VATSSA division, regardless of their home division. It also applies to students waiting for a mentor to be assigned. Students are responsible for familiarising themselves with the contents of this policy, as well as any relevant VATSIM policies. The ATC Department holds full discretion to waive or amend policy aspects as necessary for VATSSA's benefit.

The content of this document reflects the essential modifications and regulations concerning the Global Controller Administration Policy (GCAP).

2.2. Non-Compliance

Failure to comply with this policy may result in one or more disciplinary actions as outlined in Section 10. Any deviation from the requirements stated in this policy requires explicit written approval from the VATSSA ATC Training Manager (VATSSA3).

2.3. Changes

This policy is subject to periodic review and amendment. Amendments may be made by the VATSSA Training Department as required to address its clarity and effectiveness. Students will be expected to comply with the most current published version of this policy, which will be published at vatssa.com.

3. Definitions

Term	Definition
Student	Any member undergoing formal ATC training for approvals in VATSSA.
Mentor	A VATSSA-approved member instructor assigned to a student.
Examiner	A VATSSA-approved member who examines students during Controller Practical Tests (CPTs).
ATC Training Manager (VATSSA3)	The person responsible for overseeing the ATC department. Holds a Senior Instructor Rating (I3).
Deputy ATC Training Manager (VATSSA8)	The person who reports to VATSSA2 and assists with ATC training and standards.
Strikes	Basic demerits are assigned to VATSSA members following misconduct.
Controller Currency	The minimum controlling activity a controller must maintain to keep their approved rating active. Within VATSSA, this equates to three hours of controlling per quarter.
Moodle	The training and learning management platform utilised by VATSSA (moodle.vatssa.com).

eAIP	Electronic Aeronautical Information Publication, used by students for study and preparation.
CPT	Controller Practical Test — the formal examination used for rating upgrades.

4. Trainees

4.1. Training Staff and Scope

- Training is delivered by mentors. If no mentors are available, qualified VATSSA staff may step in to assist.
- Mentors train up to their current rating (e.g., an S2 mentor may train students at S1 or S2 level).
- Visiting controllers cannot be trained above their current rating.

4.2. Enrolment, Resources, and Prerequisites

- Trainees must use cc.vatssa.com and the VATSSA Discord server for all training-related activities.
- To register: navigate to cc.vatssa.com → Dashboard → Request Training. Placement on a waiting list will follow.
- When promoted from the waiting list, trainees are notified — typically via a Discord thread.
- Training materials and a theoretical examination (pass mark: **80%**) are administered via Moodle (moodle.vatssa.com). A 24-hour cooldown applies for failed attempts.

4.3. Rating Progression and Minimum Hours

The following minimum controlling hours are required before a student may progress to the next rating:

New Rating	Requirement - (Overland FSS (AFRx_FSS) : roles require a C1 rating plus additional training.)
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S2	≥ 50 hours as S1 (must include VATSSA positions)
S3	≥ 50 hours as S2 (minimum 25 hours on VATSSA positions)
C1	≥ 50 hours as S3 (minimum 40 hours on VATSSA positions)
C3	Awarded to controllers recognised for exceptional contributions to the division and controlling standards. Must be in good standing with the division.

4.4. Exceptional Recognition (C3 & Instructor Rating)

The ATC Training Manager (VATSSA3) reserves the right to recognise exceptional commitment and effort made by C1 controllers towards the division's success. In such rare and deserving cases, and at the sole discretion of VATSSA1 and ATC Training Manager, a controller may be awarded an advanced rating upgrade to C3, provided the member has demonstrated sustained exemplary conduct, work ethic, and operational competence.

The Division Director (VATSSA1) reserves the right to reward Division Training Staff tasked towards training students with the rating of Instructor (I1) or Senior Instructor (I3).

At the end of their tenure in the Division Training staff, the staff member shall return to their highest achieved ATC rating.

5. Student Responsibilities

5.1. Student Conduct

Students must conduct themselves professionally and strictly follow VATSSA and VATSIM policies at all times — including when connected to the network for any reason, and even when a conversation or instruction is not directed at them specifically.

- Treating mentors, examiners, staff, pilots, other approved controllers, and fellow students with respect is essential.
- Students must accept feedback in a mature and constructive manner. Arrogance, confrontational disagreement, and dismissal of feedback are not acceptable behaviours.

Enforcement Note: *Failure to adhere to the expected conduct will result in strikes being assigned and, depending on the severity of the situation, a hiatus and/or termination from training.*

5.2. Training Commitment

- Students are expected to be in the training room before their scheduled session time.
- Students must attend scheduled training sessions punctually. Failure to attend within 10 minutes will result in the session being cancelled and a strike being assigned.
- Students must inform mentors and examiners at least **12 hours in advance** if they cannot attend a session. Exceptions may be made for genuine emergencies.
- Students must be actively engaged during training sessions and ask questions whenever possible.
- Students must make an effort to study and prepare between sessions — including practising offline and reading the eAIP.
- Students must complete homework assigned by mentors. If homework has not been completed, the student must inform the mentor before the session begins so the session content can be adjusted accordingly.

Enforcement Note: *Repeated cancellations, no-shows, and lack of time management will be considered a lack of engagement and may result in a hiatus and/or termination from training.*

5.3. Preparation and Self-Study

- Students are encouraged to self-study and prepare, as this demonstrates commitment and sets them apart.

- Students are expected to: complete their Moodle courses; use the eAIP; and study phraseology and procedures.
- Students must seek clarification rather than guessing during scheduled and live sessions.
- Students may be assigned study material and/or recommended tools and are encouraged to make use of them.
- Students must be adequately prepared for all scheduled training sessions.
- Students are encouraged to use external resources for additional learning.

Enforcement Note: *Failure to demonstrate adequate preparation may result in sessions being rescheduled at the discretion of the mentor.*

5.4. Responsibility for Network Standards

- Maintaining high standards is a shared responsibility between students, mentors, staff, and VATSSA.
 - Students must appreciate that they represent VATSSA, and that substandard controlling that impacts the division's reputation.
 - Controlling is a privilege, not a right.
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6. Training Sessions and Oversight

6.1. Training Platform and Moodle

VATSSA utilises Moodle as its official training and learning management platform. Moodle is used to:

- Deliver training material and courses.
- Assign and submit training tasks.
- Track student progress and engagement.
- Support continuous controller progression.

Students are required to actively engage with Moodle throughout their training and must do their best when attempting theory examinations.

Enforcement Note: *Failure to engage with the required Moodle content may delay training progression or result in training being paused.*

6.2. Training Sessions

- Sessions are conducted by mentors with the aim of teaching relevant syllabus content and serve as a safe space for students to ask questions.
- Students are recommended to review Moodle training material before each session to familiarise themselves with upcoming content.
- Training sessions may take place on the live network under mentor supervision.
- Students are expected to actively participate and demonstrate progressive improvement over time.

6.3. Oversight and Observation

- Training sessions, including live controlling sessions, may be observed by VATSSA training staff.
- Observations are conducted for quality assurance, standardisation, and training support purposes — they do not imply misconduct by the student.
- Training session observations generally require consent from the mentor and student. However, unannounced observations may occur from time to time to ensure consistency of training standards.

6.4. Feedback, Records and Progression

- Feedback provided during or after training sessions and observations forms a crucial part of the student's official training record and progression.
- Students are expected to review feedback and address any concerns in subsequent training sessions.
- Feedback is typically channelled through the mentor.
- A letter of recommendation is required from the mentor before a student can progress to their checkout/CPT.

Enforcement Note: *Repeated failure to apply feedback may negatively impact training progression.*

7. Solo Certifications

7.1. Overview

A Solo Certification (Solo Cert) represents a special authorisation enabling a controller to control a station one level above their current rating. This provision is applicable for candidates pursuing S2, S3, or C1 ratings, allowing for practical network exposure before a formal Controller Practical Test (CPT). Solo Certifications are not issued for the S1 rating level.

7.2. Conditions and Limits

- Solo Certs are restricted to a single defined position and are valid for a duration not exceeding 30 days.
- A candidate may be granted a Solo Cert on no more than three independent occasions prior to a required CPT attempt.
- Controllers must reach examination standards before an issuance. These certifications are intended for live experience rather than serving as an assessment phase.

7.3. Approval and Notification Process

- A student's mentor must provide formal confirmation of readiness before a Solo Cert can be considered.
- Once mentor approval is obtained, the mentor is responsible for notifying the Training Manager or Deputy Training Manager and the relevant rating pipeline coordinator.
- The formal issuance of Solo Certifications remains the sole prerogative of the ATC Training Manager and Deputy Training Manager.

7.4. Record Keeping

- The VATSSA Control Centre (cc.vatssa.com) acts as the primary authority for all Solo Cert records, and all such authorisations shall be meticulously maintained on this platform.

8. Controller Practical Tests (CPT)

8.1. General Description and Responsibilities

Controller Practical Tests (CPTs) serve as the formal examination for rating upgrades. During a CPT, a candidate's competence in controlling a designated position will be assessed to determine whether they qualify for the relevant rating upgrade.

- Before a CPT can be requested, the student must have completed and passed the Theory Examination on Moodle.
- A letter of Recommendation must be submitted by the student's mentor, after which an examiner will be assigned.
- It is the student's responsibility to arrange an available time slot with their examiner. Students are recommended to send their availability before the letter is submitted, as this streamlines arrangements for both parties.
- CPTs should be arranged at least **14 days in advance**.

8.2. Examination Process

A CPT consists of the following stages:

- Initial Briefing and Introduction
- Practical Session (90 – 120 minutes)
- Debrief and Result
- Students must make contact with their examiner approximately **24 hours before** the exam to confirm the time of the initial briefing.
- If the student fails the CPT, the examiner will provide reasons and communicate retraining needs to the mentor.
- Assessments for S2, S3, and C1 must take place in live network environments; S1 assessments use sweatbox.
- If traffic levels are insufficient, the CPT will be considered invalid and must be rescheduled or moved to a busier location. Sweatbox may be used at the ATC Training Manager's discretion.
- The candidate must provide top-down service on at least one level below their target rating (e.g., an S3 candidate must handle TWR alongside TMA duties). Full top-down

service throughout the CPT is strongly recommended. Examiners may waive this under heavy traffic conditions where it would be impractical to control top-down after 60 minutes have elapsed.

- The examiner's decision is final. Any concerns must be raised during the debrief or within **24 hours** of the examination.

Note that all CPTs are recorded and are kept for 7 days after the examination in the event of a fail. The storage of these training records will be kept in a secure folder on the VATSSA Google Drive, where only the ATC training staff members will have access to it. Training recordings can also include the Euroscope screen as well as the AFV from the session.

9. Fast Track Programme

9.1. Overview

VATSSA's Fast Track programme provides an expedited training route for qualified Real World Air Traffic Controllers and IVAO-certified controllers to obtain VATSSA ratings. Participation is limited to members registered with VATSIM who maintain primary membership within the VATSSA division.

Ratings acquired through these pathways do not confer additional benefits or automatic endorsements; all such qualifications must be secured via standard departmental procedures. Candidates in these programmes are subject to the same regulatory oversight as standard trainees and will not receive preferential treatment beyond the specific provisions detailed herein.

9.2. Real World ATCO Fast Track

- This route is exclusively for active Real World controllers holding a valid licence.
- Qualifying individuals may be granted an S2 or S3 rating, contingent upon the scope of their professional credentials.
- Applications, including a digital copy of the relevant licence, must be directed to the Division Director (VATSSA1) for verification. This process will be actioned through the Divisions GDPR and Privacy Policy.
- Approved applicants are required to successfully complete the S1 Theory Examination via Moodle.
- Following theory completion, trainees will attend sessions focused on VATSIM regulations, local procedures, and the division's technical software stack.

- The ATC Training Manager will assess student progress before authorising a practical checkride on the live network.
- The Training Department retains the right to terminate a candidacy if operational performance or theoretical knowledge is found to be deficient.
- Upon successful completion of the checkride, the ATC Training Manager may recommend the rating upgrade for final approval by the Division Director.
- An accelerated C1 pathway exists for those possessing equivalent real-world ratings and sufficient documented experience.

9.3. IVAO Fast Track

- This pathway assists IVAO-certified controllers in transitioning their competencies to corresponding VATSIM ratings within VATSSA.
- The following rating equivalency standards are applied:
 - IVAO Approach Controller (AS3) → VATSIM S2 Rating
 - IVAO Center Controller or higher (ADC) → VATSIM S3 Rating
- Applicants must provide their IVAO identifier to the Division Director (VATSSA1) for eligibility review.
- Candidates are required to pass the S1 theoretical assessment on the Moodle platform upon initial approval.
- Mentoring sessions will follow, validating the candidate's command of VATSIM policies and the division's technical environment.
- A live network checkride will be scheduled once the ATC Training Manager is satisfied with the student's demonstrated proficiency.
- The department may reject any candidate displaying inadequate knowledge or significantly substandard controlling skills.
- Following a successful practical test, a rating assignment is recommended to the Division Director for final validation.
- Accelerated C1 training is available for candidates with appropriate IVAO credentials and significant documented controlling hours.

9.4. ATPL Fast Track

- This pathway assists ATPL-certified pilots in transitioning their competencies to corresponding VATSIM ratings within VATSSA.
- Applicants must provide their ATPL rating to the Division Director (VATSSA1) for eligibility review.
- Candidates are required to pass the S1 theoretical assessment on the Moodle platform upon initial approval.

- Mentoring sessions will follow, validating the candidate's command of VATSIM policies and the division's technical environment.
- A live network checkride will be scheduled once ATC Training Manager is satisfied with the student's demonstrated proficiency.
- The department may reject any candidate displaying inadequate knowledge or significantly substandard controlling skills.
- Following a successful practical test, a rating assignment is recommended to the Division Director for final validation.

10. Mentorship

10.1. Applying for Mentorship

- Applications must be submitted via email to atc@vatssa.com.
- Applicants must hold an S1 rating or higher and be in good standing with the division.
- The ATC Training Manager and Deputy ATC Training Manager will review the application and, if found to be in order, will begin training the applicant as a prospective mentor.
- The training process will include theory sessions, practical sessions, and a checkout. The number of sessions will depend on the applicant's progress.
- Once the required sessions are completed, the mentor will be granted a probationary mentor role and will be eligible to mentor students at S1 level.
- Once a probationary mentor has successfully mentored at least **two S1-level students**, they will be granted full S1 mentor status.
- Members with previous mentoring experience, after applying via the website, may begin mentoring at the level they previously held on a probationary basis until they have successfully mentored:
 - At least **three S2 students**, for those whose previous experience was at S2 level.
 - At least **four S3 students**, for those whose previous experience was at S3 level.
- Applicants with C1-level mentoring experience may begin in that role if their application has been reviewed and approved by both the ATC Training Manager (VATSSA3) and the Division Director (VATSSA1).

10.2. Mentor Currency

- Mentors will be assigned by the ATC Training Manager and Deputy ATC Training Manager based on their level of experience.
- Mentors may be promoted based on student level and demand.
- Mentors are required to maintain the following minimum student completion capacity:
 - S1: 2 students
 - S2: 2 students
 - S3: 1 student
 - C1: 1 student
- *Note: These capacities are subject to adjustment based on current demand and mentor availability.*
- Mentors must remain in good standing with the division at all times.

10.3. Mentor Leave of Absence and Termination

- The ATC Training Manager (VATSSA3) reserves the right to terminate any mentor who breaches the VATSIM Code of Conduct or who loses their good standing due to their behaviour.
- A mentor subject to potential termination has the right to present their case to the ATC Training Manager, Deputy ATC Training Manager, the Division Director, and the Deputy Division Director.
- Following the review, the mentor will be advised of the outcome.
- Any mentor may request a Leave of Absence (LoA) at any stage. Prior to commencing a LoA, the mentor must advise the relevant pipeline holder of the current stage of each of their students.

10.4. Mentor CPT and Checkout

- Once a mentor is satisfied that a student is ready for a CPT or checkout, the mentor must advise the pipeline holder with a letter of motivation accordingly.
- The pipeline holder will identify a suitable examiner and add them to the relevant student thread.
- The student and examiner will then coordinate a suitable date and time.
- The confirmed date and time must be provided to the Events Team for posting.
- CPT dates must be submitted as follows:
 - **All Ratings:** at least 14 days in advance.
- The mentor is required to brief the student to be ready **20 minutes before** the examination. A 5-minute grace period will be allowed. If the student fails to present

within this grace period, the examination is cancelled and recorded as a failure. It is the mentor's responsibility to confirm this briefing with the student.

**LETS ADD THE EXAMINERS THREAD IN HERE FOR
APPLYING FOR AN EXAMINER**

11. Student Rights and Support



11.1. Training Environment

- Students have the right to a respectful, professional, and constructive training environment.
- Students must be treated fairly and without discrimination during training sessions and assessments.

11.2. Feedback and Communication

- Students are entitled to clear and honest feedback following training sessions and CPTs.
- Students are encouraged to ask for clarification on feedback or training expectations in a professional manner.
- Students may not dispute training decisions during live operations or training sessions.
- Students are encouraged to use the ATC Questions and Answers Discord channel for general queries.

11.3. Escalation of Concerns

- Students may raise concerns through the ATC Training Manager and Deputy Training Manager.
- Concerns must be raised respectfully and in accordance with VATSSA procedures.
- Improper escalation or public disputes may result in disciplinary action.

12. Currency and Activity Requirements

12.1. Controller Currency

- All VATSSA-approved controllers must maintain a minimum of **3 hours of controlling per quarter** to remain current.
- Students who fail to maintain the required currency across 2 consecutive quarters will be removed from the roster and may be required to undergo refresher training before resuming training or live controlling.

12.2. Student Activity

- Students are expected to remain reasonably active throughout their training period. The Control Centre will issue an activity check when one is required.
 - Prolonged inactivity without reasonable justification may result in the student being placed on hiatus or removed from the training programme.
 - It is the student's responsibility to inform mentors or training staff of any extended periods of inactivity in advance, where possible.
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13. Enforcement

13.1. Disciplinary Action

Failure to comply with this policy may result in one or more of the following:

- Strikes being assigned
- Training being paused
- Placement on hiatus
- Termination from the training programme

Enforcement Note: *Disciplinary action will be proportional to the severity and frequency of non-compliance.*

14. Authority

- This policy is enforced by the VATSSA Training Department and authorised by the Division Director.
- Decisions made under this policy are final unless otherwise stated by VATSSA procedures.

15. Review and Amendments

- This policy is subject to biannual review to ensure continued relevance and effectiveness, or when otherwise requested by the Division Director.
 - Amendments to this policy may be made by the VATSSA Training Department as required.
 - Students will be expected to comply with the most current published version of this policy, published at vatssa.com.
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